

The Pharisee & the Tax Collector

MEMORY VERSE

"God, be merciful to me, a sinner!" — Luke 18:13 (ESV)

THE BIG IDEA

In the Parable of the Pharisee and the Tax Collector, two men go to the Temple to pray. The Pharisee proudly lists all the good things he does, while the tax collector simply asks God for mercy. Jesus said it was the humble tax collector, not the proud Pharisee, who went home right with God. We can't earn our way to God by our own good deeds — we come to Him humbly and ask for His mercy.

WHAT WE DID TODAY

We heard the story of the Pharisee and the Tax Collector from Luke 18 and watched it come to life on video. We played a stand-up/sit-down true-or-false game to help the children remember and understand the parable, had a go at our Balloon Ping Pong game to see that prayer goes two ways, and each made a fold-up mini book to bring home.

JESUS CONNECTION

The proud Pharisee thought his good deeds made him right with God, but the humble tax collector simply asked for mercy — and he was the one who went home right with God. The good news is that none of us has to earn our way to God. Jesus lived the perfect life we never could, then died and rose again, so that everyone who comes to God humbly, trusting Him, is forgiven and made right with God forever.

FOLLOW UP AT HOME

TALK ABOUT IT

Chat together about why God was so pleased with the tax collector's simple, honest prayer. What does it mean to be humble? Talk about how we don't have to pretend to be good enough to come to God — we can come just as we are and ask for His mercy. You could ask each other: "What would you like to say to God today?"

TRY AT HOME

Read Luke 18:9–14 together this week and pray the tax collector's honest prayer: "God, be merciful to me." Then read the mini book your child made and finish colouring it in together — a simple way to keep the story going through the week.

